staff warning Hezbollah of dire consequences in case of increased involvement.

In the meantime, as the fog of war is as dense as ever, let me return to my prior remarks about the basic factors that seem to determine the conflict between Israel and this or that actor, either an Arab state or the Palestinians. I pointed to the influence of religious motivations on both sides, but, of course, political considerations have played the major role in shaping the conflict.

On both sides we see a similar pattern: actors intent on finding a peaceful solution on one hand, and actors who do not believe in such a solution and consider striving for security (or taking aggressive initiatives) as the only viable policy.

On the Israeli side, there have been leaders who believed in the possibility of a peaceful solution and have endeavored to achieve it. First and foremost among them was Moshe Sharett, a longtime foreign minister and prime minister for a very short period in 1954–55. Such was also, to a lesser degree, Levi Eshkol, prime minister from 1963 to 1969, although he was more or less compelled to launch the opening gambit of the Six-Day War. Yitzhak Rabin will enter history as the leader who brokered the Oslo Accords and offered Israel a peaceful perspective regarding the Palestinian issue, and he was assassinated because of it. So too will Shimon Peres be remembered, to a lesser degree.

Most other political leaders in the country were determined security-first advocates, like the preeminent national leader David Ben-Gurion, or involuntary peacemakers like Menachem Begin, who was basically a hawk. Ariel Sharon, the most extreme hawk of all, also has this dual image, for taking Israel out of Gaza and planning to retreat from parts of the West Bank. There remains the weird figure of Golda Meir, the American-raised prime minister who, as I described in an earlier entry, denied the very existence of a Palestinian people. And also the captivating figure of a man